

Willard Robinson

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Education

North Carolina State University, Ph.D. Economics 2027 (expected)
Committee: [Spencer Banzhaf](#) (advisor), [Erin Sills](#), [Roger von Haefen](#),
[Zhenxuan Wang](#)

Montana State University, M.S. Applied Economics 2022

Appalachian State University, B.A. Economics (*summa cum laude*) 2020
Minor: Mathematics

Fields: Environmental and natural resource economics, environmental markets, nonmarket valuation

Ongoing research

Working papers

Asymmetric Information and Transaction Costs in Voluntary Conservation Markets (**Job market paper**)

Draft in progress.

Abstract: Emissions trading systems now cover roughly 30% of global greenhouse gas emissions, and offsets promise substantial gains from trade between capped sectors and cheaper abatement elsewhere. I extend van Benthem and Kerr's (2013) model of nature-based offset supply: landowners hold private information about the commercial value of their land and respond to a uniform baseline-price mechanism, but must also pay a privately known fixed cost to participate. The private information and the costly participation—acting alone—reduce the social value of such a market, but are not socially harmful. Together, however, they can be. I show that an offset market can be strictly welfare-reducing, so that closing it dominates every active policy. The two frictions play distinct roles: private information about the commercial value governs who is drawn into the market, costly participation determines how much welfare they create. Because willingness to participate is highest for those landowners with the least commercially-valuable land, the landowners who are the hardest to exclude from a market are precisely those who generate the lowest social value. Two further results follow. The optimal baseline plays a screening role absent from current protocols; and the optimal price may lie strictly below the Pigouvian benchmark, separating welfare-positive from welfare-negative landowners by exploiting differences in their willingness to participate at differing levels of policy stringency. Improving baseline accuracy, the focus of recent policy debate, is therefore necessary but not sufficient to make these markets work.

Adoption Costs for Offsets: Evidence from California

Under review.

Works in progress

Impacts of Centralized Budget Policy on National Parks: An analysis of the Federal Land Recreation Enhancement Act

The Value of Shoreline Recreational Fishing Across Time and Space: An internal meta-regression approach (with [Sasha Naumenko](#), [Colton Leach](#), and [Roger von Haefen](#))

Stability in Centralized College Major Assignment: Evidence from NCSU Engineering (with [Umut Dur](#))

Recreation Welfare Effects with Climate Change-Induced Migration

Research experience

CEnREP Graduate research assistant, (Environmental policy) with [Spencer Banzhaf](#) Jan 2024–present

Graduate research assistant (Matching theory) with Umut Dur	Jan. 2025–Jan. 2026
Graduate research assistant (Agricultural policy) with Nick Hagerty	Aug 2020–May 2022
Research assistant (Non-market valuation) with John Whitehead	June 2019–May 2020
Research assistant (Experimental economics) with Brock Stoddard	June 2019–May 2020

Teaching experience

Ph.D. = Doctorate course, *U.* = Undergraduate course

Instructor

ARE 336 (<i>U.</i>): Introduction to Environmental and Resource Economics; <i>Fall</i> '25	NC State University
ECNS 202 (<i>U.</i>): Principles of Macroeconomics; <i>Fall</i> '21, <i>Spring</i> '22	Montana State University

Graduate teaching assistant

ARE 336 (<i>U.</i>): Introduction to Environmental and Resource Economics; <i>Fall</i> '23, <i>Spring</i> '25	NC State University
ECG 702 (<i>Ph.D.</i>): Microeconomic Theory II; <i>Spring</i> '24	
EC 201 (<i>U.</i>): Principles of Microeconomics; <i>Fall</i> '22, <i>Spring</i> '22, <i>Fall</i> '23 (<i>Head TA</i>)	
ECNS 202 (<i>U.</i>): Principles of Macroeconomics; <i>Summer</i> '21, <i>Summer</i> '22	Montana State University
ECNS 403R (<i>U.</i>): Introductory Econometrics; <i>Fall</i> '20	

Seminars and conference presentations (including scheduled*)

Camp Resources, AERE @ the Southern Economic Association*, Appalachian State University*, East Carolina University*, North Carolina State University*	2026
Property and Environment Research Center, NCSU Economics Third Year Workshop, NCSU Graduate Student Seminar Series	2025
Appalachian Experimental and Environmental Workshop	2024
National Conference of Undergraduate Research (canceled due to Covid)	2020

Awards and fellowships

Andrew J. & Thelma K. Bartley Endowed Graduate Fellowship, Poole College of Management	2026
NBER travel grant	2026
First place, William D. Toussaint Best Paper Award for “Transaction Costs for Offsets: Evidence from California,” Department of Economics	2026
Property and Environment Research Center (PERC) graduate summer fellowship	2025

Professional activities

Referee service

AERE @ the Southern Economic Association conference, Environmental Research Letters

University service

Graduate student seminar organizer, NCSU

2025–present

Vice President, Economics Graduate Student Association, NCSU

2024–present

Membership

American Economic Association

Association of Environmental and Resource Economists

European Association of Environmental Resource Economists

Technical skills

Computing: Julia, Git, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Matlab, R, SAS, Stata

References

Spencer Banzhaf

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Roger von Haefen

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